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SIGMUND FREUD, the father of western psychoanalysis, once famously noted: “Dreams are constructed from the residue of yesterday.” More than 122 years later, dreams are being constructed for the world to immerse itself in by countless VFX (visual effects) studios dotting Indian cities such as Mumbai, Bengaluru, Hyderabad and Chennai. Sounds incredible? Since the late 2000s, an increasing number of movies nominated for their edge-of-your-seat VFX have had some connection with India. Think *Interstellar*, *Gravity*, *Shrek*, *Tron*, *Deadpool*, *X-Men: Apocalypse*, *Spiderman*, *The Avengers*, *The Curious Case of Benjamin Button*, *Guardians of the Galaxy*, *The Martian*, *Cinderella*... it’s a pretty long list. But even that is the proverbial tip of the iceberg. If you also included popular shows streamed on OTT platforms such as Amazon Prime Video and Netflix, the list would go on.

And who knows it better than Merzin Tavaria, President of Global Production & Operations at DNEG. Twenty-five years ago, he and his friend Namit Malhotra, along with two other friends, set up an editing studio in a garage in the western suburbs of Khar in Mumbai. The small business has since evolved into Prime Focus Ltd, the world’s largest integrated media services powerhouse that has pioneered India’s VFX revolution.

At a time when most could only marvel at the dinosaurs of *Jurassic Park* or the melting robot in *Terminator II* or bullet-time in *The Matrix* tril-

ogy, the friends dreamed of taking Indians’ famed creativity and software skills to the world. “It’s been one exciting roller-coaster ride with its share of ups and downs, twists and turns. It’s taught us to keep pushing ahead and build on our resilience to seek out new challenges,” says Tavaria over a video call from London. “Anytime there is something impossible, we make it happen! We also keep reinventing every few years to keep ourselves going.” The work has earned them accolades from all over, including seven Academy Awards for their London-based subsidiary DNEG to date.

So, why is VFX so hot these days? It eliminates dangers such as risky stunts, explosions, crashes and so on, and in the process “not only creates a superior experience for the viewers, but also gives opportunities to filmmakers and artists to expand their visual creativity and make a shot or a sequence or a film look grand and believable”, explains Keitan Yadav, COO of Red Chillies Entertainment, promoted by superstar Shah Rukh Khan. “Even animal CGI gives more freedom to mimic natural behaviour, all the while avoiding the usage of a real animal.” Yadav cites cost-effectiveness, flexibility, safety and control as key factors behind increased use of VFX in Indian movies.

And what makes India the wannabe dream factory of the world? The answer boils down to four Cs: cost, communication, creativity and computing. “Indians are very strong on creativity. They understand a creative brief and are good at blending it with technology,” points out Rajan E., Head of Human Resources & Operations at Phantom VFX. “VFX is 50 per cent creative thinking and building concepts, with the other 50 per cent technology. For example, today we are talking about virtual production using software like Unreal and Unity, where we are creating whole scenes and shots for a movie.” Phantom VFX’s Executive Producer Natalie Millar Jadhav makes a nuanced observation: “Stu-

SPINNING YARNS

► **Allocation for VFX in movies with budgets over \$100 million expected to rise to 30-35 per cent by 2023 from 25-30 per cent currently**

► **India currently has under 10 per cent of the global market share in VFX and animation**

► **This can potentially be scaled up to 25 per cent through structural interventions**

► **Indian VFX and animation expertise is available at 1/5th of the cost of their western peers**

► **A film project can save anywhere between 30-50 per cent of its budget if the work gets outsourced to India**

SOURCE TECHNICOLOR CAPITAL MARKETS REPORT, BCG-CII REPORT, INDUSTRY